



Samsung 4100

one. We'd leave it up to you to decide whether you want this feature at a cost premium.

A look now at the various miscellaneous features on these MFDs: the Canon and the Lexmark MFDs had the option to install a network card. Again, the SoHo segment may or may not use this option, and it's up to you to decide whether you really need it. All MFDs had USB2.0 as well as a parallel interface, except the Canon, which had only the USB2.0 interface. The Canon MF 3110 featured a large 64 MB buffer memory—way more than the others. This large amount of RAM is probably behind the considerably higher printing speed of the MF 3110.

All MFDs supported all versions of Windows, while the Samsung SCX-4100 even supported Linux. All of them came with quick-start guides and manuals (some with manuals on CD). Without exception, they were all bundled with some OCR software. Power cables and USB cables, too, were provided with all MFDs.

MFDs weigh more than printers, of course. The Lexmark X215, weighing in at 13.6 kg was the heaviest, followed by the Samsung SCX-4216F at 13 kg. The Samsung SCX-4100 was the lightest of them all at 8.85 kg. It also had the smallest footprint of 42.2 x 40 cm, while the SCX-4216F had the largest footprint of 47.4 x 43.6 cm.

In terms of build quality, the SCX-4216F wins hands down. But if looks are important, none of the others match up to the Lexmark X215. It has a sleek, contoured gray-and-white body.

The Lexmark X215 is priced at Rs 20,999, and comes with the Fax feature, whereas the highest-priced MFD was the Samsung SCX-4216F at Rs 34,995, which seems slightly on the higher side, especially when you are getting almost nothing extra for the premium.

Performance

We measured printing performance as we did with the laser printers. The first thing we clocked was the warm-up time. The Canon MFC 3110 and the Samsung SCX-4100 clocked similar warm-up times of 6.65 and 6.0 seconds respectively. The Lexmark was the slowest with a really slow 31 seconds, and the Samsung SCX-4216F stood third with 21 seconds.

Round Two saw the Canon taking over abd

beating the other MFDs hollow. It printed our text document in a mere 11 seconds, while the best of the rest, the Lexmark X215, took 13.19 seconds for the same job. The Samsungs had a near-tie with times of 13.5 seconds and 13.53 seconds for the SCX-4100 and the SCX-4216F respectively.

We saw the same rankings in the Best mode text quality tests, where the Canon, with a time of 13.04 seconds, was a clear 1.3 seconds faster than the second-placed Samsung SCX-4100. The Lexmark was third with 15 seconds and the Samsung SCX-4216F came in last by a small margin, clocking 15.44 seconds.

In the combi-doc speed test, Canon's advantage was further emphasised: it clocked 12.57 seconds, and was at least three seconds faster than any of the others. It was, in fact, the fastest printer in the entire test! SoHo users usually print a lot of documents, usually a mix of text and graphics. So the score in the combi-doc test matters the most.

In the quality check tests, the MFDs were all closely matched, and we had a hard time finding faults with their output!

The Samsung SCX-4216F was marginally better; the other MFDs all scored the same. We were impressed with the quality, especially considering that these are entry-level MFDs.

In our combi-doc quality tests, we looked at the resolution of the pie chart, and despite a higher rated resolution of 1200 x 600, found that the Canon MF 3110 was not as good as Samsung's SCX 4100, which was the best. Samsung's 4216 and Lexmark X215 tied for second position, and the Canon was the last by a good margin.

The 'white text on black background box' disappointed us: none of these printers passed the test well, scoring strictly average points. Again, the Samsung SCX 4100 beat the others marginally. When we tried to read the different point sizes, we found that with every printer we could read all the point sizes, right down the smallest.

Things didn't change at the top when we tested our Best Quality combi-prints. The Samsung SCX-4100 maintained its lead! This printer is all about performance, whether it's speed or quality. Second-placed here, was the other Samsung, the SCX-4216F.

In the scanner tests, the first test was, obvi-



Why Laser?

Laser Printers/MFDs	Inkjet Printers/MFDs
Laser printers print, roughly, three times faster than an inkjet when printing a large amount of copies	For a single printout, an inkjet might actually be faster, but only because lasers have a warm-up time. An inkjet is no match for a warmed-up laser printer, though
The print quality is crisp and excellent	Print quality is good, but again, not comparable to a laser. Printouts can also get smudged
Costly. Entry-level printers start at about Rs 8,500	Cheap. Entry level printers start at around Rs 3,000
Though the printers are expensive, the running costs can be as low as 65 paise per page	The running costs are quite high. In most cases, for entry-level printers, cartridges may cost as much as a new printer!
Heavy-duty toner cartridges available, with higher page yields of even 2,000 pages or more	Cartridges are of a lower yield and can print only about 200 pages